

1 Scope

- 1.1 This policy provides guidance on vulnerability and sets out the general approach that Aster will adopt in considering adjustments for customers who have disclosed a vulnerability.
- 1.2 The aim of this policy is to ensure that all customers have suitable access to Aster services. We endeavour to understand and respond to our vulnerable customers' disclosed needs to enable them to thrive in their homes and communities and we may make adjustments to the way we provide those services where we can.
- 1.3 The Housing Ombudsman Service considers vulnerability to be: 'A dynamic state which arises from a combination of a resident's personal circumstances, characteristics and their housing complaint'.
- 1.4 We recognise that vulnerabilities can be extremely varied, multi-faceted, and depend on individual situations and circumstances. Aster understands that vulnerabilities may be persistent, transient or situational.
- 1.5 We acknowledge that the word "vulnerable" can mean different things to different groups of people. In the context of services Aster delivers, it will usually mean a circumstance or current condition which is relevant to the way we deliver those services to our customers and may mean we need to make a change to accommodate that.
- 1.6 While this policy is specifically relevant to Housing Customer Services, we acknowledge that vulnerability and additional needs may also be a factor for individuals accessing other services provided by the Group, such as Care. In these cases, our broader policies and procedures for service delivery are designed to address and respond to such needs in a comprehensive and person-centred manner.
- 1.7 Through our policies, training, and service design, we aim to ensure that all customers, particularly those who may be vulnerable, receive respectful, inclusive, and effective services or support across all areas of our service provision.
- 1.8 Where appropriate we will engage in partnership working with statutory, specialist and third-party services in relation to a customer's needs.

2 Policy Statement

- 2.1 This policy outlines our approach when a customer notifies us of their vulnerability and the adjustments that they may require resulting from this disclosure.
- 2.2 We recognise that vulnerability is hugely personal and unique, and we are also aware that in some instances, specialist support will be required; and we will refer to relevant partner agencies or statutory services to provide support to our vulnerable customers where appropriate.

- 2.3 We recognise that vulnerability can arise as a result of a wide range of factors, including both protected characteristics under the Equality Act 2010 and non-protected personal circumstances. In many cases, vulnerability may be the result of a combination of these factors. Under the Equality Act 2010, and in line with our responsibilities under the Public Sector Equality Duty, we have a legal obligation to ensure that individuals are not treated unfairly or disadvantaged due to any of the following protected characteristics:
- Age
 - Disability
 - Gender reassignment
 - Marriage and civil partnership
 - Pregnancy and maternity
 - Race
 - Religion or belief
 - Sex
 - Sexual orientation
- We are committed to promoting equality, eliminating discrimination, and fostering good relations between people who share a protected characteristic and those who do not.
- In addition to the legally protected characteristics, we also acknowledge that other factors can create or exacerbate vulnerability. Our approach to supporting customers considers both statutory duties and our broader ethical commitment to fairness, inclusion, and respect.
- 2.4 We recognise that we will not always be the appropriate agency to undertake interventions or offer support in cases outside of our landlord services, and, with the exceptions of some cases relating to safeguarding concerns, customers will be advised where referrals are made to more appropriate services or agencies.
- 2.5 Customers can share with us any vulnerabilities which they feel will impact the way we deliver our service and what adjustment they feel would help. We will capture this information including where a customer declines or identifies that no changes are required.
- 2.6 We will consider vulnerability information relating to all household members, where we are made aware of this.
- 2.7 Our colleagues will receive relevant training appropriate to their role, in order to be able to recognise potential signs of vulnerability.
- 2.8 Our approach in responding to vulnerabilities, and the data we hold, is entirely dependent on our customers disclosing any additional needs in their communications with us.
- 2.9 In line with General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) principles, all data and sensitive data will be stored and reviewed in line with Aster's retention periods to comply with regulatory requirements.
- 2.10 Following a disclosure of a vulnerability and the adjustments proposed to mitigate this by the customer, the relevant service area will consider what additional support, consideration or variation in usual service provision is appropriate.

- 3.1 Policy overview sessions will be delivered to relevant teams following implementation of this policy to ensure the content and responsibilities are understood.
- 3.2 Any service failures, including the Housing Ombudsman's findings relating to vulnerability complaints will be continually reviewed.
- 3.3 Vulnerabilities captured through the client record in our core systems will be reviewed.
- 3.4 Data reviews of training attendance and policy acceptance will be completed.
- 3.5 The effectiveness of this policy will be continuously monitored, and the embedding of the policy scrutinised after 12 months by the *Customer Services Operational Leadership Team*
- 3.6 This policy will be reviewed every 3 years unless business need, Ombudsman request, regulation or legislation prompts an early review.

4 Related Policies and Procedures

This Policy, in conjunction with associated documents outlined below, sets out Aster Group's approach to meeting the requirements outlined by the RSH Tenancy Standard 2024. RSH Neighbourhood & Community Standard 2025, Safety & Quality Standard 2025 and Transparency, Influence and Accountability Standard 2025.

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues and in the public domain

- 4.1 Aids & Adaptations Policy
- 4.2 ASB Policy
- 4.3 Asbestos Policy
- 4.4 Complaints Policy
- 4.5 Customer Voice Policy
- 4.6 Damp, Mould and Condensation Policy
- 4.7 Diversity and Inclusion Policy
- 4.8 Domestic Abuse Policy
- 4.9 Empty Homes Policy
- 4.10 Gas, oil, and Solid Fuel Policy
- 4.11 Group Health & Safety Policy
- 4.12 Income Management Policy
- 4.13 Leasehold and Freehold Management Policy
- 4.14 Neighbourhood Management Policy
- 4.15 Repairs and Maintenance Policy
- 4.16 Safeguarding Children Policy
- 4.17 Safeguarding Policy
- 4.18 Temporary Re-Housing (Decant) Policy
- 4.19 Tenancy Policy

Documents available to Aster Group colleagues only

- 4.20 Abandoned Vehicle Procedure
- 4.21 Acceptable Behaviour Procedure
- 4.22 Aids & Adaptations Procedure
- 4.23 ASB Procedure
- 4.24 Asset Management Strategy 2024
- 4.25 Children Safeguarding Procedure
- 4.26 Complaints Procedure
- 4.27 Customer Accounts Procedure
- 4.28 Damp, Mould and Condensation Policy and Procedure
- 4.29 Disrespectful Behavior and Abuse of Staff Policy (Care)
- 4.30 Empty Homes Procedure
- 4.31 Environmental ASB Procedure
- 4.32 Eviction Procedure
- 4.33 Financial Wellbeing Service Procedure
- 4.34 Fire Management Procedure
- 4.35 Health & Safety Inspection Procedure for Independent Living Schemes
- 4.36 Lettings Policy & Procedure
- 4.37 Lettings Procedure and Tenancy Check Procedure
- 4.38 Mutual Exchange Procedure
- 4.39 Neighbourhood Inspection Repairs Reporting Procedure
- 4.40 Neighbourhood Inspections Procedure
- 4.41 Neighbourhood Nuisance Procedure
- 4.42 Permission to share Procedure
- 4.43 Property Condition Procedure
- 4.44 Section 20 Policy and Procedure
- 4.45 Section 21 Procedure
- 4.46 Starter Tenancy Procedure
- 4.47 Temporary Re-Housing (Decant) Procedure
- 4.48 Tenancy Check Procedure
- 4.49 The Neighbourhood Inspection Procedure
- 4.50 Under-Occupancy and Overcrowding Guidance
- 4.51 Water Safety Management Procedure

5 Governance			
Effective From:	19/09/2025	Expires:	19/08/2028
Policy Owner:	Regional Operations Director- Customer Service Central		
Policy Author:	Policy Officer		
Approved by:	<i>Customer Services Operational Leadership Team</i>		
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